

Suggested Note

This manuscript represents an exploratory conceptual framework currently under theoretical development. The content is hypothesis-generating in nature and should not be interpreted as clinical guidance, medical recommendation, or validated empirical conclusion.

The framework is intended solely for theoretical discussion regarding recursive cognition, affective persistence, trauma-related processing, and compensatory regulatory mechanisms.

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Title

Recursive Cognitive Overload and Relief-Oriented Substance Dependence:
A Multi-Layer Recursive Occupation Framework within the Constraint-Driven Divergence Model (CDDM)

Abstract

Persistent depressive and trauma-related states are frequently associated with intrusive recursive cognition, chronic self-referential processing, emotional overload, interpersonal inhibition, and impaired attentional disengagement. Conventional addiction models primarily emphasize reward-seeking behavior and dopaminergic reinforcement mechanisms. However, certain forms of substance dependence may instead emerge from attempts to suppress persistent internal cognitive pressure and recursive affective occupation.

This conceptual paper proposes an expanded framework based on the Constraint-Driven Divergence Model (CDDM), in which unresolved affective input (#1) that cannot be successfully integrated or symbolically encoded through emotional processing mechanisms (#0) persists as recursive background activation (#2), resulting in chronic recursive occupation (#3).

Within this framework, recursive occupation is not conceptualized as equivalent to normal cognition itself. Rather, recursive occupation refers to a persistent, difficult-to-terminate state of recursive replay, attentional capture, affective reactivation, and self-monitoring emerging secondary to unresolved emotional activation. Under this interpretation, recursive cognition is proposed not as the primary origin of suffering, but as a secondary interpretive response to unresolved affective persistence.

The framework further proposes that persistent background activation may consist of multiple unresolved layers rather than a singular affective structure.

Primary trauma-origin layers may emerge from:

- emotional invalidation
- attachment disruption
- coercive control
- humiliation
- betrayal
- developmental suppression of emotional autonomy
- prohibition of authentic emotional expression

Existential-social layers may emerge from:

- prolonged invisibility
- perceived absence of recognition
- unresolved self-validation pressure
- inability to establish meaningful interpersonal impact
- chronic perception of not being seen or acknowledged

Reality-adaptive layers may emerge secondarily from prolonged occupation itself, including:

- chronic anticipation of rejection
- social filtering
- altered interpersonal interpretation
- persistent defensive monitoring
- trauma-associated world perception

The framework additionally proposes that trauma-related recursive occupation may progressively alter perceptual-affective interpretation of the external world. Under prolonged recursive occupation, social ambiguity, silence, interpersonal distance, or lack of feedback may become increasingly interpreted through defensive or threat-associated filtering structures.

Simultaneously, attachment-oriented interpretive drives may remain active despite trauma-related distrust. This may produce a contradictory state in which individuals perceive the world as emotionally unsafe while continuing to seek recognition, understanding, attachment, or interpersonal goodness from others.

Within this framework, prolonged exposure to environments involving emotional suppression, forced self-inhibition, chronic invalidation, or suppression of autonomous emotional existence may contribute to amplification of recursive self-monitoring and progressive elevation of self-validation drive (\$2).

The framework proposes that persistent recursive occupation may progressively distort motivational allocation, increasing the proportional dominance of unresolved validation-related motivational structures over time.

The paper further proposes that some forms of psychoactive substance dependence may function primarily as relief-oriented suppression mechanisms rather than purely pleasure-oriented reinforcement systems.

Under this interpretation, psychoactive substances may temporarily reduce:

- recursive occupation intensity
- intrusive replay
- self-monitoring
- interpersonal inhibition
- affective pressure
- background activation persistence

The framework distinguishes reward-oriented reinforcement from relief-oriented regulation. In relief-oriented regulation, subjective relief from recursive pressure may partially precede and generate the experience of pleasure itself.

The model additionally proposes that suppression-oriented regulation possesses functional limits. Certain high-intensity affective triggers, including traumatic recall, interpersonal betrayal exposure, attachment-related activation, psychologically threatening environments, or unresolved developmental memory activation, may exceed suppression capacity and reactivate recursive overload despite ongoing suppression attempts.

The framework further proposes that reduction of recursive burden may emerge not solely through emotional labeling, but through successful symbolic reconstruction and acknowledgment of previously resisted relational realities, including:

- recognition of emotional neglect
- acknowledgment of absence of attachment reciprocity
- recognition of coercive relational structures
- acknowledgment of unresolved interpersonal harm
- acceptance of previously denied emotional realities

Under this interpretation, recovery is not conceptualized as erasure of emotional memory, but as progressive reduction of unresolved recursive pressure through successful symbolic integration and stabilization of interpretive structure.

Finally, the framework proposes that many defensive personality structures may emerge secondarily from persistent recursive occupation rather than representing intrinsic personality architecture itself. Excessive self-monitoring, emotional masking, compulsive filtering, interpersonal inhibition, defensive social adaptation, and compulsive self-validation may partially represent adaptive responses to unresolved recursive occupation.

This framework remains exploratory and hypothesis-generating in nature and is intended to support future investigation into recursive cognition, trauma-related processing, layered affective occupation, self-model formation, interpersonal inhibition, compensatory suppression-oriented regulation, and trauma-associated world-model reconstruction.